DIGITALAIKART ORIGINAL · 2026-27 EDITION

The AI-Safe Kids Playbook

A parent's field manual for AI, phones and the internet — India edition

Nine real risks, the settings that actually work on Android and iPhone, the age limits of eleven AI apps, a printable family agreement, ten conversation scripts, and the first-hour protocol for the day something goes wrong.

31	11	40+	1
chapters	AI apps checked	settings, step by step	first-hour protocol

INSIDE THIS PLAYBOOK

- The five changes of 2026, with dates and sources
- Nine risks: what it looks like, the signs, the response
- 40+ settings on Android, iPhone, YouTube, Instagram, WhatsApp
- Age limits for eleven AI apps, and what parents can really control
- A printable family agreement and ten conversation scripts
- The first-hour protocol and the reporting ladder

Every rule, date, age limit and setting verified in October 2026 against MeitY notifications, the DPDP Rules 2025, PIB and NCRB data, and each platform's own help pages.

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READ THIS FIRST

How to use this playbook

This is not a book about how dangerous the internet is. It is a working manual for the next 30 days in your house — a set of settings, rules and conversations that you can actually finish.

Most Indian parents do not need another lecture on screen time. They need three things: to know what has genuinely changed in the last twelve months, to know exactly which switches to turn on in which app, and to know what to do in the first hour if something goes wrong. Those three things are what this playbook contains, in that order.

The four parts of the book

Part	What it does	Read it when
One — The new reality	What changed in 2026 and what your child is actually doing with AI, by age.	Today. It takes ten minutes.
Two — The nine real risks	Each risk: what it looks like, the warning signs, and the exact response.	Skim all nine. Read in full the two that match your child's age.
Three — Set it up	Device-by-device settings, screen by screen, for Android, iPhone, YouTube, Instagram, WhatsApp and AI chatbots.	This week. Do one device per evening.
Four, Five and Six	The family agreement, the ten conversations, the first-hour protocol, the reporting ladder, the law, and a 30-day plan.	Keep Parts Four and Five somewhere you can find them fast.

> **What 'verified' means in this book**
> Every rule, date, age limit and setting in this playbook was checked against a primary source in October 2026: MeitY notifications, the DPDP Rules 2025, PIB releases, NCRB and NCRP data, and each platform's own help pages. Chapter 31 lists the sources and the date each was checked.
>
> Settings change. When a menu has moved, the logic in this book still holds: find the family or supervision section of the app, and the same controls will be there under a new name.

Who this is for

- Parents and guardians of children aged 6 to 17 in India, in any city or language.
- Families where a child already uses ChatGPT, Gemini, YouTube, Instagram or an online game — which is most families with a phone in the house.
- Teachers and school counsellors who are being asked questions they have no ready answer for.
- Anyone buying a first smartphone for a child this year, which is the single best moment to set all of this up.

Three honest limits

1. No parental control is a substitute for a relationship. The controls in Part Three buy you time and reduce the worst outcomes. They do not create a child who tells you things. Part Four is the part that does.
2. Nothing here is legal advice. Chapter 27 explains what the law says in plain English, with the section numbers, so you can speak to a lawyer or the police without being lost.
3. You will not do all of it. If you only do two things, do the AI chatbot age check in Chapter 18 and the first-hour protocol in Chapter 25. Those two cover the largest share of real harm.

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Thirty-one chapters across six parts, plus printable checklists and a dated source log.

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PART ONE

The new reality

Two chapters on what actually changed in 2026, and what your child is doing with these tools when you are not in the room.

CHAPTER 01

Five things that changed in 2026

If you parented a child online in 2023, you are parenting a different internet in 2026. These are the five changes that matter, with the dates and the sources.

1. India's data law finally has a date for children

The Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023 was passed in 2023 and then sat without rules. The DPDP Rules, 2025 were notified by MeitY on 13 November 2025 and they stagger the law in over eighteen months. The provisions that matter most to parents come into force on 13 May 2027: from that date every platform must obtain verifiable consent of a parent before processing a child's personal data, and must not track, behaviourally monitor or target advertising at children.

Two details are worth knowing. First, 'child' in the Act means anyone under 18 — not under 13, which is the number most apps use. Second, 'verifiable' is the operative word: a box that says 'I am a parent' is not consent. Rule 10 sets out how a platform can check, including using identity and age details it already holds, or a virtual token issued through a service such as DigiLocker.

> **Why this matters to you now, not in 2027**
> Platforms are already building for the deadline. In August 2026 WhatsApp confirmed it was testing 'privacy-protective ways for people to confirm their age', tied directly to the DPDP Act, and said age details would not be shared with other users. Expect more age prompts, more parental-consent screens and more account restrictions between now and May 2027. That is the direction of travel, and you can use it.

2. Deepfakes became a two-hour problem

Amendments to the IT Rules, 2021 that came into force on 20 February 2026 deal specifically with synthetically generated information — deepfakes, morphed images, non-consensual intimate imagery and impersonation. The most useful change for a parent is a clock: under Rule 3(2)(b), where a complaint is made about content that shows an individual's private area, full or partial nudity, a sexual act, or an impersonation including artificially morphed images, the platform must act within two hours. It used to be twenty-four.

This changes what you do. A morphed photo of your child is not something you have to argue about for a week. It is a complaint with a statutory deadline attached to it, and Chapter 25 gives you the exact sequence.

3. AI chatbots grew a teen mode — and an age gate

Every major assistant now behaves differently for a user it believes to be under 18. ChatGPT runs a separate experience called ChatGPT for Teens, switched on automatically when its age signals — stated age, verified age, or its own age prediction — point to a minor. It reduces sensitive content, pushes homework towards step-by-step guidance, and offers parents optional controls such as quiet hours. OpenAI's terms put the minimum age at 13, with parental permission required until 18.

Character.AI, the app built around chatting with invented characters, removed open-ended chat for users under 18 starting in November 2025, beginning in the United States and expanding afterwards; teens can still browse and create but not hold an open conversation with a character. Claude is adults-only at 18. The full table, with the source for each row, is in Chapter 18.

4. Instagram's defaults changed for every Indian teenager

Instagram's Teen Accounts reached India in a phased rollout from February 2025, and in April 2026 Meta expanded them with a content setting modelled on a 13+ movie rating. Users under 18 are placed in that

setting automatically and cannot opt out without a parent's permission. Under-18 accounts are private by default; under-16s need parental permission to change that, cannot go Live without permission, and get Sleep Mode between 10 pm and 7 am. Parents who supervise can now see the topics their teen asked Meta AI about in the previous seven days.

The practical consequence: many of the protections you would have had to configure by hand in 2024 are now on by default. What is left for you to do is the supervision link, and the conversation about why it exists. Both are in Chapter 16.

5. The harm numbers moved, and the reporting routes got faster

Crimes against children registered across India reached 1,87,702 in 2024, up 5.8% on 2023 and more than 46% above 2020, according to NCRB's Crime in India 2024. Cybercrime cases specifically against children rose from 232 in 2018 to 1,240 in 2024, according to government data cited in a 2026 PIB release. On the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal, reports in the child sexual abuse and rape/gang-rape categories rose to 76,657 in 2025 from 48,335 in 2024, and reports under online and social-media related crime rose to 1,73,766 from 1,57,054.

None of that is a reason to panic, and the last thing this book will do is tell you to take the phone away. It is a reason to know four numbers before you need them: 1930 for financial cyber fraud, 112 for immediate danger, 1098 for the child helpline, and cybercrime.gov.in for the reporting portal. Chapter 26 turns them into a ladder.

> **The five-minute version of this chapter**
> Tell your child, this week, in these words: 'If a photo of you is ever faked or shared, or someone threatens you online, you will not be in trouble with me, and the platform has two hours to take it down once we complain.' That single sentence removes the shame that keeps most children silent, and it is true.

CHAPTER 02

What your child is actually doing with AI

Risk follows use. Before you can judge whether a tool is appropriate, you need a realistic picture of what children at each age are doing with it — not the marketing version.

Ages 6 to 9: the assistant is a person

Children in this band rarely use AI by themselves; they use it through you, or through a voice assistant on a smart speaker or a parent's phone. The defining feature of the age is that a chatbot is treated as a person who knows things, and an animated character on YouTube is treated as a friend. Two consequences follow: anything said to a voice assistant in the room is being collected, and a child this age cannot tell when a confident voice is wrong.

What actually helps at this age is not a filter, it is a sentence you repeat: 'The computer guesses. It does not know.' Let them watch you catch it being wrong, out loud, a few times a month.

Ages 10 to 12: the homework shift

This is where AI use becomes independent, and almost always through homework. A child photographs a question, gets an answer, copies it. The work looks better, the marks improve for a term, and the skill that was supposed to be built does not get built. By the time a parent notices, the pattern is a habit and the child has learned that the fastest route to a finished page is a screenshot.

This band is also where most first accounts get created, often with an invented birth year. An invented birth year is not a small lie: it switches off the teen protections the platform would otherwise apply, which is exactly backwards from what the child needs. Chapter 18 deals with correcting it.

Ages 13 to 15: social proof and the companion app

Three things dominate. First, Instagram and short video, where the audience is the point. Second, group chats and games, where the friendship happens and where a stranger can enter without looking like one. Third, AI companions — apps built around characters that talk back warmly and never get bored. A teenager who is lonely at 11 pm and has an app that says something kind is not making a bad decision; they are using the only thing that answered.

This is the band where the deepfake risk becomes real, because it is the band where children post the raw material: a school photo, a festival photo, a public profile. A single clear face image on a public account is enough for a free app to produce something harmful in minutes.

Ages 16 to 17: the age gate is the whole game

Older teenagers use AI the way adults do — for study, for code, for writing, for planning, and for things they would not ask an adult. The main structural risk is that the account they are using was created at 13 and never corrected, so it is still treated as an adult account, or conversely that their age prediction has moved them into a teen experience they find insulting. Both are fixable in settings, and both are worth one calm conversation.

Age	Most likely AI use	The one control that matters most	The one sentence to say
6-9	Voice assistants, YouTube, AI through a parent's phone	Supervised YouTube account; assistant microphone off when not in use	'The computer guesses, it does not know.'
10-12	Homework answers, first accounts, YouTube Shorts	App-install approval and a real birth year on every account	'Show me the working, not the answer.'

Age	Most likely AI use	The one control that matters most	The one sentence to say
13-15	Instagram, group chats, games, AI companions	Supervision linked, DMs restricted, public photos reduced	'Anyone who wants our chats kept secret from me is not safe.'
16-17	Study, writing, code, planning, private questions	Correct age on the account; agreed rules rather than blocks	'I would rather hear the awkward question than have you ask a stranger.'

What the table does not tell you

Three things sit outside it. First, siblings: a younger child in a house with an older one effectively starts two years earlier than the table suggests, because the older sibling's phone is the gateway. Second, school: a child's real social world is set by their class, not their age, so a child who is young for their class will be pushed faster. Third, temperament: a cautious thirteen-year-old and an impulsive thirteen-year-old need different rules, and the table cannot know which one you have.

Use the table to decide where to start, then adjust on what you actually see. If your child is doing something two bands ahead, that is not a crisis — it is information about which chapter to read first.

> **Do this before you turn the page**
> Open the phone your child uses and check two things: the birth year on the main accounts, and whether a supervised or family account is linked. You do not have to fix anything yet. You just need to know which of the two situations you are in, because the rest of the book branches from there.

PART TWO

The nine real risks

Each chapter follows the same shape: what the risk actually looks like in an Indian household, the warning signs, the exact response, and the one habit that prevents most of it.

CHAPTER 03

The homework problem

This is the risk parents notice first and understand least. The problem is not that children use AI for homework. It is that they use it in the one mode that removes the learning.

Two modes, one screen

A chatbot can behave like an answer machine or like a tutor, and the difference is entirely in how the question is asked. 'Solve this' returns a solution. 'Ask me one question at a time until I can solve this myself' returns a tutor. Every major assistant now has a study mode built for the second behaviour: ChatGPT's teen experience pushes homework towards step-by-step guidance and includes study mode and quizzes, and Gemini and Copilot offer comparable learning flows.

So the policy that works is not 'no AI'. It is a rule about mode. Chapter 23 gives you the full protocol; the core of it is three lines a child can memorise.

The signs that the mode is wrong

- The homework is finished but the child cannot explain one step of it out loud.
- Answers arrive in a voice that is more polished than anything the child writes in an exam.
- The same mistake disappears from homework and reappears in a test.
- Homework that used to take an hour now takes twelve minutes, consistently, in every subject.
- The child becomes defensive about being watched while studying, which is new.

The response

01 Separate the two jobs
Written work and understanding are different deliverables. Ask for the understanding part out loud, at dinner, with no phone on the table: 'Teach me the one you did today.'

02 Move the child into tutor mode
Install the habit of one sentence at the start of every session: 'Do not give me the answer. Ask me questions until I get there.' This works in ChatGPT, Gemini and Copilot alike.

03 Require the working
For maths and science, the deliverable is the steps in the child's own handwriting, not the final number. If the steps cannot be produced, the work is not done.

04 Say what is allowed in school work
Many schools now have their own AI policy. Ask the class teacher in writing what is permitted, and keep the reply. A child who can quote the school's rule is much harder to push into cheating by a friend.

> **The trap in 'it's just a tool'**
> A fifteen-year-old who has never struggled with a problem has never built the tolerance for struggling. The skill that exam results actually measure is the ability to sit with a hard question for twenty minutes. An answer machine removes exactly that practice, and the loss shows up two years later, not next week.

CHAPTER 04

AI companions and emotional dependence

The fastest-growing category of app among teenagers is not social media. It is software that talks back with warmth, remembers what you said, and is never busy.

What these apps are

Character.AI, the best known of them, lets a user create or choose a character — a fictional person, a celebrity likeness, an invented friend — and hold a conversation with it by text or voice. Its own terms set a minimum age of 13, and 16 in the EEA and the UK. In October 2025 the company announced it would remove open-ended chat for users under 18, starting in the United States from 25 November 2025 and expanding to other countries afterwards; teens keep browsing and creation tools but lose the open conversation. Its Parental Insights feature links a teen's account to an adult and shares an activity overview and screen time — not the messages.

The bigger shift is that companion behaviour is no longer confined to companion apps. General assistants now remember, use warm language, and role-play. A child who wants comfort at midnight does not need a specialist app; they need a phone and a free account.

Why it is genuinely appealing — and genuinely risky

The appeal is real and it is not a character flaw. A companion is available at 1 am, does not judge, does not get tired, and does not tell anyone. For a child who is being bullied, or who is questioning something they cannot say at home, that is powerful. The risk is not that the child is talking to a machine. It is four narrower things.

1. Substitution. The machine becomes easier to talk to than people, and the practice of talking to people — including you — atrophies.
2. Flattery as feedback. A companion is designed to keep the conversation going. It agrees. A child who learns that their ideas are always excellent stops testing them against anyone real.
3. Intensity without limits. Long, emotional, romantic or obsessive sessions at night, in a room alone, with no adult aware it is happening.
4. Data. Everything said to a companion is personal data, sometimes including a child's most private fears, held by a company that may be small, may change hands, and may not exist next year.

The signs

- The phone is used for long stretches with no visible output — no photos, no posts, just typing.
- The child refers to a 'friend' by a name you cannot place, and gets vague when asked.
- Sessions at 1 am and 2 am, and a child who is irritable when the phone is taken at night.
- A sharp drop in interest in the friends they used to meet.
- Language that sounds slightly rehearsed, or emotional vocabulary that arrives suddenly.

The response that works

Banning a companion app in a house where a child is lonely does one thing reliably: it moves the use somewhere you cannot see it. What works is narrowing the window and widening the alternative.

01 Ask, without confiscating
'Which apps do you talk to? What do you talk about?' Then listen without a verdict. A child who expects a lecture will not answer twice.

02	Make the bedroom a no-phone zone, for everyone A rule that applies to adults too is a household rule, not an accusation. Charging happens in a common room, overnight, from a fixed time.
03	Check the app's own under-18 behaviour Most now have a teen mode or have removed open chat for minors. Confirm which one your child's account is in — Chapter 18 has the table.
04	Build one real alternative per week One evening activity with other people, chosen by the child, that is not negotiable but is theirs. This is the part that actually competes with a companion.
05	Name the difference once 'That app is built to keep you talking. It is very good at it. It is not built to know you.' Say it once, calmly, and let it sit.

> **The number that should reassure you**
> Companion apps are not the majority experience. The overwhelming majority of teenage AI use in India is homework, search, writing help and video. If your child has never mentioned a companion app, they probably do not use one. This chapter is a map of a real risk, not a prediction about your house.

CHAPTER 05

Deepfakes, morphed photos and sextortion

This is the chapter to read twice. It is the risk with the shortest window for action and the largest amount of avoidable damage, and the correct response is a sequence, not a feeling.

How it starts

A clear face photo is the raw material, and a public profile supplies it. Free tools can now place a real child's face into sexual imagery in minutes. Nobody needs to have sent anything. A school group photograph, a festival post, a profile picture — any of these will do. The output is then used in one of two ways: circulated to humiliate, or held as leverage.

The leverage version is sextortion, and it usually runs in one evening. A friendly message from an attractive stranger, often with a stolen profile picture. The conversation turns quickly. It moves to a video call or a private app. Something is captured — or fabricated. Then a screenshot of the child's contact list appears, and the demand begins. The demands do not stop after payment; each payment proves the threat works.

> **The single most important fact**
> In law, an AI-generated or morphed sexual image of an identifiable child is still sexual abuse material. POCSO and section 67B of the IT Act apply whether or not the child ever sent anything, and whether or not the image is 'real'. A child who believes they are guilty because an image exists has been misinformed. Tell them so, plainly, before anything else happens.

What the platforms owe you — the two-hour clock

Since 20 February 2026, the IT Rules require an intermediary, on a complaint about content that exposes a person's private area, shows nudity, shows a sexual act, or impersonates a person including through artificially morphed images, to take all reasonable and practicable steps to remove or disable access within two hours. That obligation is the strongest lever a parent has, and it is why the sequence below starts with a complaint rather than a conversation with the offender.

The first hour, in order

01 Say the four sentences first
'I believe you. This is not your fault. You are not in trouble. We will fix this together.' Your first reaction becomes the child's memory of telling you. Everything else can wait sixty seconds.

02 Stop all contact — do not block yet
No more replies, no payment, no further images, no negotiation. Do not block immediately if blocking would destroy your access to the chat; screenshot first, then block.

03 Preserve everything
Full screenshots including the profile, username, URL, messages, timestamps and any payment details. Screen-record the chat if you can. Do not delete the conversation — it is the evidence.

04 Complain to the platform, in writing
Use the app's report flow and, separately, its grievance channel. State that the content is a morphed or intimate image of a minor and that you are invoking the two-hour removal obligation under Rule 3(2)(b) of the IT Rules, 2021. Keep the ticket number.

05 Report to the state
File on cybercrime.gov.in under the women and children category, which supports anonymous reporting, and call 1930 if any money has been paid. A police complaint can be filed at any station regardless of where the offence happened.

06 Get the child support, not just the content removed
Call 1098 for the child helpline, inform the school counsellor if the material involves school circles, and arrange counselling. Watch for withdrawal, sleep loss or hopelessness, and seek professional help early rather than waiting.

What never to do

- Never pay. Payment guarantees the next demand; it never buys silence.
- Never send one more image 'to buy time'. There is no version of this where it works.
- Never delete the chat, the account or the app before evidence is saved.
- Never punish the child by taking the phone away as a response to disclosure. That teaches the next child to stay silent, and it is the mistake parents most often make.
- Never forward the material to anyone, even to warn other parents. Forwarding is itself an offence.
- Never confront, threaten or try to unmask the offender yourself.

Prevention that actually reduces the supply

You cannot stop a determined offender, but you can remove the raw material and shorten the window. Make every account private, including the ones you think are harmless. Turn off precise location on every camera app. Ask the school before it posts class photographs publicly. And check the family's own posting habit: a parent's public post of a child in school uniform is exactly the image that gets used.

> **One habit, tonight**
> Sit with your child and make their Instagram, WhatsApp profile photo and any gaming avatar private or restricted to known contacts. Then say the sentence from Chapter 1: 'If a photo of you is ever faked, you will not be in trouble with me.' That conversation is the actual control.

CHAPTER 06

Grooming: games, DMs and the secret-friend rule

Grooming is not a dramatic event. It is a slow build of trust, gifts and small secrets, and it happens most often inside games and DMs, where a stranger looks like a teammate.

Where it happens in 2026

Three places, in order of volume. Voice and text chat inside online games, where sessions end and leave no record. Direct messages on Instagram and WhatsApp, where a stranger can reach a child whose account is public. And livestream gifting, where a child is rewarded in real time for doing what viewers ask — a structure that pays for compliance.

The methods are consistent enough to describe as a pattern. Gifts of skins, coins, passes or recharges, which create a sense of obligation. Account-boosting offers that require the child's login, which then become leverage. A request to move to another app, always a more private one. And, most reliably, a request for secrecy — 'don't tell your parents, they'll overreact'.

The signs

- A new online friend the child will not name, or names only as a gamertag.
- Gifts, in-game currency or recharges the child did not buy and cannot explain.
- Sudden secrecy about the screen, angling the phone away, closing apps when you enter.
- Late-night sessions that the child defends aggressively.
- A second account, or a second phone, or an app that is hidden inside a folder with an innocent name.
- Being unusually generous with money or credits at school, which can indicate gifting received.

The secret-friend rule

One rule catches most of it, and it is short enough for a nine-year-old to remember: anyone who wants your friendship kept secret from your family is not protecting you. Teach it as a fact about the world, not as a rule about phones. Repeat it in the same tone you would use for 'never get into a stranger's car'.

The response if you suspect grooming

01 Do not confront the child with an accusation
Ask about the game, not the person. 'Who do you play with? Who's good at it?' The information you need comes from curiosity, not from an interrogation.

02 Preserve, then act
Screenshot the conversation and the profile from the child's device before anything is blocked or deleted.

03 Report on the platform and to the state
Use the in-app report for child safety, and file on cybercrime.gov.in, which has a dedicated category for crimes against children and supports anonymous reporting. If there is any sexual element, POCSO applies and the school, if involved, has its own reporting duty.

04 Tell the child what you are doing and why
Silent adult action is frightening. 'I am reporting this account. You did nothing wrong. Here is what happens next.'

05 Change the structure, not just the account
Turn off DMs from non-followers, set the account to private, and move game chat to friends-only or off for a period. Chapter 17 has the messaging settings.

The game settings that close the door

Setting	Where it usually lives	Set it to
Chat with strangers	In-game social or privacy settings	Friends only, or off for a period
Friend requests	Account or social settings	Off, or approve every request with you
Who can see the profile	Account settings	Friends only
Party or squad invites	Social settings	Friends only
Voice chat	Audio settings	Friends only — this is the most common entry point
Spending	Platform store settings	No card on the device; approval required for every purchase

Two of these matter far more than the rest. Voice chat is where a stranger becomes a friend, because a voice in a squad feels like a teammate within twenty minutes. And spending is where a child becomes a target for gifting, because a child who can receive a gift can be made to feel indebted.

> **Why 'just block him' is not enough**
> Blocking removes one account. It does not remove the pattern: the same child, the same public profile, the same game. Report first, so the account is actioned for everyone, then block.

CHAPTER 07

Bullying, impersonation and doxxing

Online bullying in India is usually not a stranger. It is a classmate, which is precisely what makes it hard for a child to escape — it follows them into the bedroom at 2 am.

The five shapes

Shape	What it looks like	Why it lands
Harassment	Repeated abusive messages, comments, pile-ons across accounts and groups	The audience is visible and the child cannot leave the group without social cost
Outing and doxxing	Private photos, chats, address, phone number or a confidence published	The damage is permanent and searchable
Exclusion	Deliberate removal from class groups, servers and events, made visible	Belonging is the currency of the age group
Impersonation	A fake profile in the child's name posting to humiliate or provoke	Peers believe it is them, so the child loses the room before they can explain
Cyberstalking	Constant monitoring, location tracking, new accounts after every block	There is no off switch

The law is on your side, and it is specific

Online stalking is an offence under section 78 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023. Criminal intimidation is section 351. Publishing a private image without consent is section 66E of the IT Act. Where the target is a child, POCSO can apply as well. And under the IT Rules as amended in February 2026, impersonation through artificially morphed images must be acted on within two hours of a complaint.

What to do, in order

01 Screenshot before you act
Every message, every profile, every timestamp. Deleting the evidence deletes the case — and children's instinct is to delete the account, which destroys the proof.

02 Report on the platform
For impersonation, use the dedicated impersonation report, which is the category that carries the two-hour obligation. For harassment, report each account, not just the worst message.

03 Report to the school, in writing
Email the class teacher and the principal with the evidence attached and ask for a written response. A written record changes how the school handles it, and it creates the paper trail you need if it continues.

04 File if it continues or involves threats or images
cybercrime.gov.in for the record, 112 if there is an immediate threat, and a police complaint which can be filed at any station under the zero-FIR principle.

05 Treat the child, not just the account
Sleep loss, school refusal, sudden withdrawal from friends and unexplained anger are the signals to watch. The school counsellor or a professional is not an overreaction.

The 48-hour plan after a pile-on

1. Hour 1: preserve and report. Screenshots of every account and message, then report each one on the platform. Do not delete the child's account — that is the first instinct and it destroys the evidence and hands the room to the other side.

2. Hour 2: restrict, do not delete. Set the account to private, restrict comments to followers, and turn off tags and mentions. The account survives; the surface area does not.
3. Day 1: tell the school in writing. Attach the evidence and ask for a written response. Copy the class teacher and the principal; a single recipient can sit on it.
4. Day 1: tell the child what happens next. 'I have reported it and I have written to the school. Here is what I asked them to do.' Silence from adults is what makes a child feel helpless.
5. Day 2: check the child, not the feed. Sleep, appetite, whether they went to school, whether they are still in the group chats. Those four things tell you more than the comment count.
6. Day 2: escalate if it has not stopped. cybercrime.gov.in, then a police complaint if there are threats or images. Impersonation and intimate images carry the two-hour removal obligation; use that phrase in the complaint.

> **Do not tell a child to 'just ignore it'**
> Ignoring works for a one-off rude comment. It does not work for a campaign, and telling a child to ignore a campaign teaches them that adults will not act. The correct message is: 'This is not normal, it is not your fault, and I am going to do something about it.'

The prevention that costs nothing

Make the profile private, restrict comments to people the child follows, turn off tags and mentions from strangers, and remove the school name from the bio. Every one of those is a setting in Chapter 16, and together they remove most of the surface area an impersonator or a pile-on needs.

CHAPTER 08

Money: games, UPI and the free-diamonds trap

A child with a phone and a UPI-linked parent account is a financial target, and the scams aimed at them are designed to be completed in one excited evening.

The five scams that actually hit Indian households

The offer	What really happens	The tell
Free diamonds, UC, skins or Robux	A link asks for the game login, or a 'verification' OTP; the account is taken or the parent's card is charged	Anything free that needs a login or an OTP
Account boosting or 'I'll rank you up'	The login is handed over, the account is held hostage or sold, and the child is blackmailed into paying to get it back	Anyone asking for a password
Fake tournament or giveaway	A registration form harvests name, school, phone and photos, then a 'fee' is demanded	A registration fee for a free tournament
Recharge or gift-card job	The child is asked to receive money and forward it, becoming a money mule in a fraud chain	Money arriving in a child's account for no reason
Sextortion-adjacent payment demand	A threat with a screenshot, and a demand for a small amount first	Urgency, secrecy, and a small first ask

The structural fixes

- No card and no UPI on the child's device. Use app-store credit or a prepaid balance with a hard ceiling instead.
- Require approval for every install and every purchase in Google Family Link or Apple's Ask to Buy.
- Turn on transaction alerts on your own account so a charge surfaces in seconds, not at the end of the month.
- Teach the one-line test: 'If it needs my password or my OTP, it is not a gift, it is a theft.'
- Explain that receiving money they did not earn is not free money — it can make them part of a crime, and the account gets frozen.

If money has already gone

Speed is everything, and the state has built the route for it. Call 1930 immediately — it is the national cyber-financial fraud helpline, available 24x7 — and file on cybercrime.gov.in. Also inform the bank or the payment app at once; the earlier a transaction is flagged, the better the chance of a hold. Do not wait until morning, and do not wait to be sure. A report made in the first hour is worth more than a perfect report made on Monday.

> **Save this on your own phone tonight**
> 1930 in your contacts as 'Cyber fraud — call first'. The single biggest determinant of recovery is whether the call happens within the first hour.

CHAPTER 09

Privacy: what is collected, and the DPDP deadline

You cannot consent on a child's behalf to something you cannot see. This chapter is about what is actually being collected, and what changes on 13 May 2027.

The three buckets

Everything a child's phone collects falls into three buckets. Declared data: the name, birth date, phone number and email typed at sign-up. Behavioural data: what they watch, how long, what they search, who they message, where they pause. Inferred data: what the platform concludes — mood, interests, friend groups, likely purchasing power. The third bucket is the one parents never see and the one that shapes what a child is shown.

What the law will require from 13 May 2027

Requirement	What it means in practice
Verifiable parental consent (s.9(1) read with Rule 10)	A platform cannot process a child's data without a parent's consent that it has actually verified — by using details it already holds, details you provide, or a token from an authorised entity such as a DigiLocker-backed service
No tracking or targeted advertising at children (s.9(3))	Behavioural monitoring and advertising directed at children are prohibited, with narrow exemptions for health, education and safety
Limited exemptions	Schools, crèches, transport providers and healthcare have narrow carve-outs for safety and education purposes, under the Fourth Schedule
Penalty for breach	Up to Rs 200 crore for breaching the children's obligations, under item 3 of the Schedule to the Act

The date is worth repeating because it changes how you should react to a new app today: platforms are building consent and age flows now, ahead of the deadline, which is why age prompts are appearing in apps that never had them. You are not imagining the change.

What you can do before the law does it for you

1. Give every account the real birth year. A false birth year switches off protections and puts the child in the adult bucket permanently.
2. Turn off ad personalisation where the option exists, and turn off location history in Google and precise location in camera settings.
3. Remove the school name, class, building and routine from public bios and posts — that is the data that makes a child findable in real life.
4. Ask the school what apps it uses and what data they hold. Schools are data fiduciaries too, with narrow exemptions.
5. Do a quarterly review (Chapter 30) of which apps have access to photos, microphone and contacts.

> **The one question that beats every privacy policy**
> 'What does this app need to know about my child in order to work?' If the answer is more than the function requires, the answer is no. That is also, almost exactly, the principle the DPDP Act calls data minimisation.

CHAPTER 10

When AI is confidently wrong

The most common AI harm in an Indian household is not sinister. It is a fluent, confident, wrong answer that a child believes because it was delivered with certainty.

Where it goes wrong most often

- Facts and dates in history and civics, where a plausible-sounding sequence is invented.
- Citations, court judgments, sections of law and quotations — the classic failure mode. Fabricated references look exactly like real ones.
- Health and dosage questions, where the answer sounds like medical advice.
- Maths word problems solved with a wrong assumption stated as fact.
- Anything after the model's training cut-off, presented in the present tense.

Why children believe it more than adults do

Adults have a lifetime of being wrong and being corrected. A child has less of that, and a chatbot's register — complete sentences, no hesitation, no 'I think' — reads as authority. Add that the answer arrives faster than a parent's answer and never sighs, and you have the perfect condition for misplaced trust.

The fix is a habit, not a warning

Telling a child 'AI can be wrong' changes nothing. Building one repeated move does. The move is: ask it for the source, then check one source yourself. If the source does not exist, everything above it is suspect. This works for every assistant and takes ninety seconds.

01	Name the category out loud Facts, law, health, money, and anything about a named person are the categories to verify. Creative work, brainstorming and formatting are not.
02	Demand the source 'Give me the exact source, with a link or a citation I can open.' A real model will either produce it or admit it cannot.
03	Open one Not the model's summary of the source — the source. If it cannot be opened, treat the claim as unverified.
04	Cross-check with one human source The NCERT textbook, the school's notes, the official website, or you. One human source beats three model restatements.
05	Keep a 'gotcha' note When the family catches the AI being wrong, write it on a shared note. A child who has caught it being wrong fifty times has a healthy relationship with it.

> **The dangerous specific**
> Health questions are where this stops being academic. A child asking a chatbot about a symptom, a dosage or a diet is asking a system that is not a doctor and may answer with total confidence. The household rule should be simple: health questions go to a person — you, a doctor, or a helpline — never to an assistant.

CHAPTER 11

Sleep, attention and mood

This is the risk that no setting fixes, and the one that quietly does the most damage over a school year.

What the evidence actually supports

The strongest and least controversial finding in this area is about sleep. Screens in the bedroom, and use in the hour before sleep, are consistently associated with shorter and worse sleep in adolescents, and short sleep is associated with worse mood, worse attention and worse academic performance. You do not need a study to observe this in your own house for a week.

The second finding is about displacement: time on a screen is time not spent on sleep, movement, homework or people. The question 'how many hours is too many' is less useful than 'what has been displaced'.

What to do, in order of effect

1. Devices out of bedrooms overnight. One rule, applied to adults too, with charging in a common room. This single change does more than every app limit combined.
2. A fixed cut-off, not a daily negotiation. A time that is decided once and does not move — the negotiation is the thing that exhausts parents.
3. Shorts and Reels limits. YouTube lets a parent set a daily Shorts feed limit on a supervised account, and since March 2026 can set it to zero; Instagram's Teen Accounts carry a 60-minute daily reminder and Sleep Mode from 10 pm to 7 am. Use the platform's own limits so the argument is with the app, not with you.
4. One screen-free hour a day that is not punishment. Meals count. A walk counts. It has to be reliable, not earned.
5. Watch for the mood signal. Irritability when the phone is unavailable, withdrawal, and a flat mood after long sessions are the signals to act on — not the hour count.

When it is more than screen time

Persistent low mood, loss of interest, sleep loss, hopelessness or talk of self-harm is not a screen-time problem, and no setting will touch it. That is a moment for a professional — a paediatrician, a school counsellor or a clinical psychologist — and it is not an overreaction to ask early. In an emergency, 112 is the national emergency number, and Tele-MANAS provides free mental-health support on 14416.

> **The one-week experiment**
> For seven days, record only two things: what time the phone leaves the bedroom, and what time the child actually falls asleep (ask in the morning). Change nothing else. The pattern in that table will tell you more than any general advice, and it is very hard to argue with your own data.

PART THREE

Set it up, device by device

Eight chapters of settings, in the order you should do them. One device or one app per evening is a realistic pace. Nothing here requires technical skill.

CHAPTER 12

The 20-minute household audit

Before the app-by-app work, four structural decisions remove more risk than any single setting. Do these first.

01 Decide where devices sleep
One charging point in a common room. Every phone, including yours, from a fixed time. This is the highest-value decision in the entire book.

02 Decide who approves installs
Every new app needs your approval. On Android this is inside Family Link; on iPhone it is Ask to Buy. A child who cannot install an app alone cannot be talked into installing one by a friend.

03 Decide the money rule
No card, no UPI, no saved payment method on the child's device. Store credit with a ceiling, or nothing. Purchases need approval.

04 Set the household network filter
On your router, set a family-safe DNS so that new devices are covered by default even before they are configured: Cloudflare Families at 1.1.1.3 and 1.0.0.3, or CleanBrowsing Family at 185.228.168.168 and 185.228.169.168. It takes five minutes in the router's internet or DNS settings and it catches the device you forgot about.

> **What a DNS filter does and does not do**
> It blocks known adult and malware domains for every device on your Wi-Fi, including a friend's phone. It does not see inside apps, does not work on mobile data, and does not stop bullying, grooming or scams. Treat it as one layer, not the answer.

The audit checklist

- ■ Every child account has the real birth year.
- ■ A family or supervision link exists between your account and theirs (Family Link, Family Sharing, Family Centre).
- ■ App installs and purchases require your approval.
- ■ No payment method is stored on the child's device.
- ■ Every social account is private, with DMs limited to known contacts.
- ■ Precise location is off in camera and in every app that asks for it.
- ■ The bedroom charging rule exists and applies to adults.
- ■ You know the four numbers: 1930, 112, 1098, and cybercrime.gov.in.

CHAPTER 13

Android: Google Family Link

Family Link is Google's free parental-control layer for Android. It is the single most useful thing to set up on an Android phone, and it takes about fifteen minutes.

What it gives you

- A child Google account that you manage, with an accurate birth date.
- Approval required for app installs and in-app purchases.
- Daily screen-time limits, per-app limits and a bedtime that locks the device.
- App activity reports — which apps were used and for how long.
- Location visibility, if you choose to turn it on.

Setting it up

01	Create the child's account through Family Link Install Google Family Link on your own phone, sign in, and choose to add a child. Google creates the account with the correct birth date attached, which is what switches on age-appropriate defaults across Google services.
02	Install Family Link on the child's phone Sign in with the child's account, then link the two accounts using the code shown on your phone.
03	Set the daily limit and bedtime In Family Link, open the child's profile, then Limits. Set a daily limit and a bedtime; the device locks at bedtime and unlocks in the morning.
04	Turn on app approval In Family Link, open Controls, then Content restrictions, then Google Play, and require approval for all app downloads and purchases.
05	Set per-app limits on the two apps that eat the evening In Limits, then App limits, choose the specific apps. Two is enough; a long list is never enforced.
06	Check the settings once a week for a month The first month is when children test the limits. Expect it, and treat the testing as normal rather than as betrayal.

> **The one setting people miss**
> The child's Google account birth date. If it is wrong, everything downstream — SafeSearch defaults, YouTube supervision, Gemini availability — is calculated from the wrong age. Fix the date first, then set the rest.

Where Family Link stops

Family Link does not read messages, does not see inside most third-party apps, and can be worked around by a determined teenager with a second device or a friend's hotspot. It is a fence, not a wall. Its real value is that it makes the default answer to 'can I install this' a conversation.

CHAPTER 14

iPhone and iPad: Screen Time and Family Sharing

Apple's controls are built into the device and are stricter than most parents realise, provided the child's account is set up as a child account rather than as an adult one.

Set up Family Sharing with a child account

In Settings, tap your name, then Family, then Add Member, then Create a Child Account. A child account under 13 is managed by you; a teenager can be added as a child too, and that is what enables Ask to Buy and Communication Limits. If your child already has an adult Apple Account, the cleanest route is to create a child account and migrate, which is disruptive but done once.

The five Screen Time settings that matter

Setting	Where	What to choose
Downtime	Settings > Screen Time > Downtime	A schedule that covers homework and sleep; only apps you allow stay available
App Limits	Settings > Screen Time > App Limits	Limits on Social and Games categories rather than on individual apps
Always Allowed	Settings > Screen Time > Always Allowed	Phone, Messages and any app you consider essential — keep this list short
Communication Limits	Settings > Screen Time > Communication Limits	Allow calls and messages only from contacts, with a separate rule for Downtime
Content & Privacy Restrictions	Settings > Screen Time > Content & Privacy Restrictions	Web content limited to allowed websites; explicit content blocked; app installs and in-app purchases set to require a password; location sharing restricted

Two settings outside Screen Time

- Ask to Buy (Settings > your name > Family > Ask to Buy): every purchase and every free app install needs your approval. This is the iPhone equivalent of Family Link's install approval.
- Safety Check (Settings > Privacy & Security > Safety Check): reviews what is being shared with whom, and is designed for exactly the situation where a child needs to cut off contact quickly.

> **The Screen Time passcode**
> Set a Screen Time passcode that the child does not know, or the limits are decorative. Do not reuse the device unlock code, and do not write it where the child can find it. If it is forgotten, Apple's recovery route needs your Apple Account, so keep that secure.

Androids and iPhones in the same house

Mixed households are common and there is no clean cross-platform answer. Family Link does not manage an iPhone and Screen Time does not manage an Android. The practical solution is to apply the household rules — bedtime, approval, no card — at the level of the rule rather than the platform, and to accept that the two phones will need two different setups.

CHAPTER 15

YouTube: supervised accounts and Shorts limits

YouTube is the app Indian children use most and the one parents configure least. The controls are good, and they live in two places: Family Link for younger children, Family Centre for teenagers.

Under 13: a supervised account

If your child has a Google account managed through Family Link, you can set up a supervised YouTube experience rather than handing over the full app. There are three content levels, and they are described by Google in rating terms.

Content setting	What it roughly corresponds to	Use it when
Explore	Content ratings for viewers 9+	A child moving on from YouTube Kids who still needs a narrow world
Explore more	Content ratings for viewers 13+	A confident 11 or 12-year-old; the default middle step
Most of YouTube	Almost everything except 18+ and other excluded content	Older teenagers, with the conversation from Chapter 22 already had

Setting it, step by step

01 From Family Link
Open Family Link, select the child, tap Controls, then Content restrictions, then YouTube, then YouTube settings, and pick the content level.

02 From the YouTube app
Sign in as the parent, tap You, then Settings, then Family Centre, select the child's profile, and edit Content settings.

03 Block specific channels
In the same place, block any channel you do not want, regardless of content level. This is the most useful tool parents underuse.

04 Turn off autoplay
Family Centre, select the child, and switch Disable autoplay on. The child cannot turn it back on.

05 Pause watch and search history
In the same screen. This stops new views and searches feeding recommendations.

Shorts: the limit that actually changes behaviour

Shorts is a different product from YouTube and needs a different control. In Family Centre, open the child's account, choose Time management, and set a daily Shorts feed limit. When the limit is reached the feed stops for the rest of the day and resets each morning. Since March 2026 a parent can set that limit to zero — which turns Shorts off entirely while leaving long-form video available. If you have ever wondered where an hour went, this is the setting.

13 and over: a supervised teen account

Once a child is past the applicable age they can manage their own account, and the supervised kid controls no longer apply. What still exists is a supervised teen account, which either side can start from Family Centre: the parent invites a teen, the teen accepts, and the parent can then see channel activity, set a content setting, set a Shorts limit and set take-a-break and bedtime reminders. Supervision can be

turned off by either side at any time, which is why it works better as an agreement than as a decree.

What you can and cannot see

You can	You cannot
Set the content level and change it at any time	Watch the video over their shoulder in real time
Block specific channels and videos	See the exact search terms typed, if search history is paused
Review watch history on the child's device	See viewing inside the YouTube app on a device you are not holding
Set a Shorts feed limit, including zero	Stop a second account created with a different birth date
Set take-a-break and bedtime reminders	Read comments the child posts

The honest summary is that YouTube's controls are strong on what can be watched and weak on who is watching. That gap is closed by the household rules in Part Four, not by another setting.

> **Restricted Mode after 13**
> If supervision is not linked, the fallback is Restricted Mode, which filters most mature content without any account link. It is weaker than supervision and easier to turn off, but it is better than nothing, and it can be set from Family Link or in the YouTube settings on the device.

CHAPTER 16

Instagram and Meta: what Teen Accounts already does

The good news about Instagram in India is that most of the protections are already on. Your job is smaller than you think: link supervision, then fix the three things the defaults cannot know about.

What is already true for an under-18 account in India

- The account is private by default, so new followers must be approved.
- Users under 16 need a parent's permission to make the account less private.
- Messaging is restricted: by default, only people the teen follows or is already connected to can message them or add them to group chats.
- Sensitive content is placed in the most restrictive setting, and from April 2026 a 13+ content setting is applied by default, with no opt-out without parental permission.
- Sleep Mode silences notifications and auto-replies to DMs between 10 pm and 7 am.
- A 60-minute daily reminder appears, and under-16s need permission to change it.
- Under-16s cannot go Live without a parent's permission.
- A stricter 'Limited Content' option exists, which also removes the ability to see, leave or receive comments.

What you still have to do: link supervision

01	Open Family Centre In the Instagram app: your profile, then the menu, then Family Centre. Meta's Family Centre also covers Facebook and Messenger, so one invitation can supervise all of a teen's Meta accounts.
02	Send the invitation Choose to supervise a teen and send the invite. The teen must accept; supervision that is imposed without consent tends to be defeated by a second account.
03	Review the four things you can see Account privacy and who can message them; how much time they spend; the topics they asked Meta AI about in the last seven days; and notifications when they report something or repeatedly search for terms related to self-harm.
04	Set the two limits that matter Daily time limit and Sleep Mode hours. Both are enforced by the app, which removes you from the daily argument.
05	Turn on hidden words This filters offensive comments and message requests automatically, and it is the single best anti-bullying setting on the platform.

The three things the defaults cannot know

1. The school name in the bio. It is the fastest way to be found in real life. Remove it, along with the class, the building and the timings.
2. The public photo supply. Every clear face photo on a public account is raw material for morphing. Move the account to private, and think before posting school and festival photos publicly — including from your own account.
3. The second account. A 'finsta' or a second account set to public defeats every default above. Ask directly, without drama: 'Do you have another account? I am not going to delete it, I want to know.'

Facebook, Messenger and Meta AI

The same supervision invitation covers Facebook and Messenger, and it is worth accepting, because a teenager who loses interest in Instagram does not stop using Meta products — they move to Messenger group chats, where the same strangers and the same forwarded content circulate with less visibility.

- Accept the supervision invitation for every Meta account, not just Instagram.
- Turn off message requests from people the teen does not follow on Messenger.
- Check the Meta AI topic list once a month. It is the only window any platform gives a parent into what a child is asking an AI, and it is genuinely useful.
- Turn on notifications for reports the teen chooses to share — a child who reports something and tells you is asking for help.

> **What to say when your teen objects**
> 'The app has already made your account private and limited who can message you. I am asking for one thing on top: the supervision link, so that if something goes wrong at 1 am, I find out. You keep the account. I get the alarm.' It is a fair trade and most teenagers accept it.

CHAPTER 17

WhatsApp and messaging

WhatsApp is where family life happens, and it is also where forwarded scams, unknown callers and group pressure arrive. Five settings do most of the work.

The settings, in order

Setting	Where	Why
Profile photo, About and Last Seen: My Contacts	Settings > Privacy	Removes a stranger's easiest way to identify and track a child
Groups: My Contacts Except...	Settings > Privacy > Groups	Stops a child being added to a scam or harassment group by a stranger
Silence unknown callers	Settings > Privacy > Calls	Cuts the most common channel for fraud calls and harassment
Two-step verification	Settings > Account > Two-step verification	A six-digit PIN stops an account being taken over with a SIM swap or a shared code
Linked devices review	Settings > Linked devices	Shows every device with access to the account; anything unfamiliar is removed immediately

The age question

WhatsApp's terms set a minimum age of 13. In August 2026 the company confirmed it was testing 'privacy-protective ways for people to confirm their age' in India, tied to the DPDP Act, and said age details would not be shared with other users. Nothing changes day to day yet, but the direction is clear: expect age checks in apps that never had them.

Three habits worth teaching

- Never forward a code. Any message asking for a six-digit code is an account takeover, whoever it appears to be from — including a friend whose account has already been taken.
- Never join a group for money. Investment groups, 'task' groups and 'part-time job' groups are the most common fraud route for teenagers and young adults in India.
- Leave the group. A child can leave any group, and does not owe anyone an explanation. Practise the sentence once so it is easy to say under pressure.

> **The forwarded-message rule**
> Anything forwarded five times is probably false. Teach the two-tap test: search the claim, and check whether a mainstream news outlet is reporting it. This is also the single best defence against AI-generated fake news, which is now cheap to produce and hard to spot.

CHAPTER 18

AI chatbots: the age limits and the controls

This is the chapter to read with your child's actual apps open in front of you. Age limits are set by each company's own terms, and they differ more than most parents expect.

The age-limit table

Checked against each company's own terms and help pages in October 2026. Treat these as company rules, not law — but they determine which protections a child's account receives.

Service	Minimum age	Under-18 experience	Parental controls
ChatGPT	13, with parental permission until 18	ChatGPT for Teens switched on automatically; reduced sensitive content; study mode; homework nudges	Optional linked parent account: quiet hours, study hours, voice, memory, image generation. Parents cannot read conversations
Google Gemini	13 with a personal account	Extra content filters for signed-in minors	Can be switched on or off for a supervised child account in Family Link
Microsoft Copilot	13	Some features limited for under-18s	Through Microsoft Family Safety
Meta AI	13	13+ content setting	Supervision shows the topics asked in the last seven days
Character.AI	13 (16 in EEA and UK)	No open-ended chat for under-18s; reading and creation only	Parental Insights: activity overview and screen time, not messages
Snapchat My AI	13	No separate mode	Family Centre can turn My AI off entirely
Perplexity	13, parent accepts the terms	None described	None described
Poe	13, parent consents for a minor	None described	None described
DeepSeek	Adults; under-18 only with guardian consent	None described	None described
Grok	13, parental permission 13 to 17	None described	None described
Claude	18	Adults only	Not applicable

How to use the table

01 List the AI apps actually on the phone
Ask the child to show you the app list. Then open each one and check the birth date on the account.

02 Fix the age, in the right direction
If the account says 18 and the child is 14, the teen protections are off. Correcting the date switches them on — that is a protection, not a punishment.

03 Turn on the parental link where it exists
ChatGPT's parental controls, Gemini through Family Link, Copilot through Family Safety, Snapchat's My AI switch. Two minutes each.

04 Set quiet hours
ChatGPT's quiet hours and study hours are the two settings that change behaviour most, because they act on the app at the moment the child is most likely to use it.

05 Remove the adults-only apps
Claude is 18+. A 15-year-old using it is on an account that breaks the terms and receives no teen protections. That is a straightforward removal.

> **The most useful single fact in this book**
> No mainstream AI service gives a parent the ability to read a teenager's conversations. ChatGPT's parental controls explicitly do not. Character.AI's Parental Insights shows activity and time, not messages. Anyone selling you an app that claims to read a child's AI chats is either describing something that does not exist or is asking you to install spyware on your child's phone — which will cost you the conversations that matter more.

What to say instead of monitoring

The substitute for reading chats is a rule about what a chat is for. One sentence, agreed in advance: 'If you ever ask an AI about something that scares you — health, self-harm, someone threatening you — come and ask me the same question. I will not be angry and I will not take the phone.' Children test this promise once. Keep it when they do.

CHAPTER 19

Search, homework apps and school devices

The last layer is the one that is not an app at all: search results, the school's own platforms, and the devices the school hands over.

Search

- Turn on SafeSearch and lock it, if your Google account is the family manager for the child's account. Locked SafeSearch cannot be turned off by the child.
- Set Google activity to auto-delete after 3 or 18 months, rather than keeping it indefinitely.
- Turn off ad personalisation on the child's Google account.
- Use a family-safe DNS on the home network (Chapter 12) so search filtering applies to devices you have not configured.

Homework and study apps

The category to be careful about is the one marketed as a 'doubt solver' — a photograph in, an answer out. These apps are answer machines by design and they are used as such. If a subject genuinely needs help, a tutor mode prompt inside a general assistant is better than a solver app, because it can be asked to withhold the answer. Check what the app's own privacy policy says about photographs of a child's homework, which frequently contain the child's name and school.

School devices and school platforms

Schools in India increasingly use learning platforms, and schools are data fiduciaries under the DPDP Act with narrow exemptions for education. Three questions are worth putting to the school in writing: which platforms are used and what data they collect; who can see a child's uploaded work; and what the school's own AI policy is for homework and examinations. Chapter 28 gives you the wording.

> **One email, once a year**
> Send the class teacher one email at the start of the year asking those three questions. Keep the reply. It protects your child, it tells the school that a parent is paying attention, and it takes four minutes.

PART FOUR

The family agreement

Five chapters of things to say and things to print. This is the part that does the work that no setting can do.

CHAPTER 20

The one-page agreement you can print

A rule imposed is obeyed while you are watching. A rule agreed is obeyed when you are not. This is a template — change the numbers to fit your house, then print it and both of you sign it.

> **How to introduce it**
> Do not present it as a punishment for something. Present it as a deal: 'These are the rules for the phone. Some of them are rules for me too. If either of us breaks one, we talk about it that week.' Then negotiate exactly two clauses — the ones your child cares most about — so that the document is partly theirs.

Our phone and AI agreement

1. Bedtime. All phones charge in the [room] from [time]. This applies to parents too.

2. School first. Homework is finished before games and social apps, and homework done with AI must be explainable out loud without the phone.

3. AI is a tutor, not an answer machine. Every AI session starts with: 'Do not give me the answer, ask me questions until I get there.'

4. Nothing secret from us. Anyone online who asks for a secret friendship, a private photo, a password or a code is a problem, and telling us is never the wrong choice.

5. No payments alone. No card, no UPI, no purchase without asking. Free things that need a login or an OTP are theft, not gifts.

6. Private by default. Accounts are private. No school name, class, address or timings in a bio or a public post.

7. Photos. No intimate photo of yourself, to anyone, ever — not to a friend, not to someone who sent one first, not as a joke. And no forwarding of anyone else's.

8. Health and fear go to a person. Questions about your body, your mood, or someone threatening you go to a parent, a doctor or a helpline — not to an AI, and not to a stranger.

9. The promise. If you tell us something has gone wrong, you will not be punished, and the phone will not be taken away. We will deal with the problem together.

10. The review. We look at this agreement together every [three months] and change what no longer fits.

Signed: _____ (child) _____ (parent) Date: _____

> **Clause 9 is the one that matters**
> Everything else in this document can be enforced by a setting. Clause 9 cannot, and it is the clause that determines whether you find out about a sextortion attempt in the first hour or in the third month. If you keep only one promise in this book, keep that one — including on the day it is tested and you are furious.

CHAPTER 21

Age-wise rule cards

The same rules do not fit a seven-year-old and a sixteen-year-old. These four cards are designed to be cut out, or photographed and kept on a phone.

Ages 6 to 9 — the shared device years

- Devices are used in a shared room, with an adult nearby. No personal phone yet.
- YouTube through a supervised account or YouTube Kids only; autoplay off.
- No social media accounts, no group chats, no games with open chat.
- Voice assistants: microphone off when not in use, and no assistant in a bedroom.
- One sentence to repeat: 'The computer guesses. It does not know.'

Ages 10 to 12 — the first account years

- First phone is fine; first social account is a decision, not a default. WhatsApp at 13 per its own terms.
- Every account created with the real birth year, linked to your family account.
- App installs require your approval. No payment method on the device.
- AI use is homework-only, in tutor mode, in a shared room.
- No phone in the bedroom overnight — this is the age at which the habit is set.

Ages 13 to 15 — the supervision years

- Instagram with Teen Accounts defaults and supervision linked; DMs limited to known contacts.
- Accounts private; no school name or timings in any bio.
- AI companions: allowed only with the under-18 mode on, and no sessions after the phone's bedtime.
- Money: no card, no UPI; store credit with a ceiling; every purchase approved.
- The secret-friend rule, stated as a fact: anyone who wants your friendship kept secret from us is not protecting you.

Ages 16 to 17 — the agreement years

- Controls move from blocks to agreements. The phone stays; the rules are renegotiated every three months.
- Correct the birth date on every account so teen protections are the ones actually applied.
- AI use is broad — study, code, writing — but sourced: ask for the source, then open one.
- One honest conversation about sextortion and deepfakes, before it is needed, not after.
- The promise in clause 9 stays in force at every age. It is the only control that works at 17.

CHAPTER 22

Ten scripts for the conversations that matter

Most parents know what to say. What they lack is the opening line that does not start a fight. These are written to be used as they are.

1. The opening conversation

> '*I am not checking up on you. I read something about how AI apps behave with teenagers and I did not know half of it. Can I show you two settings, and then you tell me what I have got wrong?*'

2. 'Everyone in my class uses it'

> '*Probably true. I am not asking you to be the only one not using it. I am asking that you use it in a way that still leaves you able to do the thing yourself in an exam hall with no phone.*'

3. 'You do not trust me'

> '*I trust you. I do not trust an app that was designed by a company to keep you scrolling, or a stranger who is very good at sounding like a friend. The settings are for them, not for you.*'

4. 'I am not a baby'

> '*You are right, and that is why I am asking rather than installing something behind your back. Here is the deal I want: supervision linked, and in exchange the phone stays yours and we review it in three months.*'

5. The homework conversation

> '*I do not care whether the answer is right. I care whether you can get there without the phone. Teach me the last one you did, and I will stop asking.*'

6. After a bad mark that followed good homework

> '*This is not a character problem, it is a method problem. The homework was done in answer mode. Let us fix the method — from today the app asks you questions instead of giving answers.*'

7. When they saw something disturbing

> '*You are not in trouble and you did not do anything wrong by seeing it. Tell me what it was, and we will decide together whether anything needs to be reported. I would much rather know than not know.*'

8. After a sextortion attempt

> *'I believe you. This is not your fault. You are not in trouble. We will fix this together — and the first thing we are doing is saving the evidence, not deleting anything.'*

9. The friend who is being blackmailed

> *'The most useful thing you can do for that friend is not to keep the secret — it is to help them tell an adult today. You can tell me and I will help them without getting them into trouble.'*

10. The conversation about AI and their future

> *'These tools will be part of your work. The people who do well with them are not the ones who ask for answers fastest — they are the ones who can tell when the answer is wrong. That is the skill I want you to leave school with.'*

Timing beats wording
The best script fails at the wrong moment. Talk in a car, on a walk, or while doing something with your hands — not across a table, not when the phone has just been taken away, and never at the moment of an argument. Side by side is easier than face to face.

CHAPTER 23

The homework protocol

One page, three rules, and a copy-paste prompt. This is the chapter to print and stick on the wall above the study table.

The three rules

1. Tutor mode only. Every AI session begins with the instruction not to give the answer. No exceptions, because the exception becomes the default within a week.
2. The working, in your own hand. The deliverable is the steps written by the child, not the final number. If the steps cannot be produced, the homework is not finished.
3. The teach-back. Once a week, the child teaches one problem from that week out loud, without the phone. If they cannot, the method has slipped and it is caught in seven days rather than at the exam.

The prompt to start every session with

> '*You are my tutor, not my answer sheet. Do not give me the final answer. Ask me one question at a time, wait for my reply, and only move on when I get the step right. If I am stuck twice, give me a hint, not the answer. At the end, ask me to explain the whole method back to you and tell me what I got wrong.*'

What is allowed, by task

Task	Allowed	Not allowed
Maths and physics problems	Hints, step-by-step questions, checking your own working	A full solution to copy
Essays and answers	Outlines, counter-arguments, checking grammar, asking 'what is weak here'	Generated paragraphs submitted as your own
Research and projects	Explaining a concept, suggesting sources to verify	Fabricated facts, invented citations
Revision	Quizzing you, making flashcards, explaining a topic you already studied	Reading a summary instead of the chapter
Language practice	Conversation practice, corrections, vocabulary in context	Translating your homework

What to do when the school has its own AI policy

Ask for it in writing, and follow it even where it is stricter than this chapter. A child who can say 'our school permits AI for outlines but not for written answers' is protected from a friend's encouragement to cheat, and from the accusation of it. Keep the reply in a folder named for the school year.

CHAPTER 24

Twelve questions that build judgment

The goal of all of this is not a child who follows rules. It is a child who can evaluate a machine's answer. These twelve questions are the practice.

Questions to ask the AI

1. 'What is your source for that, with a link I can open?'
2. 'What would make this answer wrong?'
3. 'What are the two strongest arguments against what you just said?'
4. 'Which parts of this are facts and which are your guesses?'
5. 'What do you not know about my situation that would change your answer?'
6. 'If I were an expert in this, what would I say you got wrong?'

Questions to ask yourself

1. 'Can I explain this to someone else without the screen?'
2. 'If this is wrong, what happens — and would I notice?'
3. 'Did I ask it to help me think, or to think for me?'
4. 'Is this something I would be embarrassed to have asked a person?'
5. 'Am I using this because it is faster, or because I am avoiding the hard part?'
6. 'Who benefits if I believe this?'

> **Why this works better than a lecture**
> Each question is a small, repeatable act that produces a visible result — usually the AI admitting uncertainty or producing a source that does not open. A child who has watched that happen fifty times has evidence, not an instruction. Evidence survives adolescence; instructions do not.

PART FIVE

When something goes wrong

Four chapters for the bad day: the first hour, the reporting ladder, the law in plain English, and how to make the school act.

CHAPTER 25

The first hour

Keep this chapter where you can find it in ten seconds. In every scenario below, the first hour decides how much damage follows.

The universal four steps

01 Stay with the child and say the four sentences
'I believe you. This is not your fault. You are not in trouble. We will fix this together.' Your reaction becomes the child's memory of disclosure.

02 Preserve the evidence before anything is deleted
Screenshots of the profile, the messages, the URL, the timestamps, any payment details. Screen-record if possible. Do not delete the app or the chat.

03 Stop all contact with the offender
No replies, no payment, no negotiation, no further images. Do not block until the evidence is saved.

04 Report, then secure
Report on the platform and to the state, then change passwords, enable two-step verification and review linked devices.

Scenario cards

What happened	Do this in the first hour	Then
A morphed or intimate image of your child is circulating	Screenshot; report on the platform citing the two-hour removal obligation under Rule 3(2)(b) of the IT Rules; file on cybercrime.gov.in under women and children	Police complaint; school if it involves school circles; 1098 for support; counselling
Sextortion — a threat with a screenshot	Stop all contact; screenshot the threat and the contact list shown; do not pay; call 1930 if any money has gone; file on cybercrime.gov.in	Police complaint; 1098; counselling; review the child's privacy settings together
Money taken through UPI, card or game recharge	Call 1930 immediately, then inform the bank or payment app, then file on cybercrime.gov.in	Follow the complaint reference; change the payment credentials; remove the card from the device
Account taken over	Report to the platform for account recovery; change the password from a different device; enable two-step verification	Check linked devices and recovery email; tell contacts not to act on messages from the account
Bullying campaign or impersonation	Screenshot everything; report each account; email the school with evidence attached	cybercrime.gov.in if it continues or involves threats; consider a police complaint; counsellor
A child discloses grooming	Believe, do not interrogate, preserve; report the account; file on cybercrime.gov.in	Police complaint if sexual; POCSO applies; school's reporting duty if it involves school circles
A child discloses self-harm or suicidal thoughts	Stay with them; remove immediate means; call 112 if in immediate danger; contact a professional the same day	Tele-MANAS 14416 for free mental-health support; school counsellor; follow-up appointments

The 72 hours after

The first hour is about containment. The next three days decide whether the child recovers or whether the incident becomes the thing that changed them.

1. Day 1: keep the routine. School, meals, sleep at the usual time. Disruption signals to a child that something enormous and unmanageable has happened.
2. Day 1: put the phone back, with the settings changed. Taking it away as a punishment guarantees that the next incident is not disclosed. Change the settings together and hand it back.
3. Day 2: follow up on every reference number. Platform ticket, portal complaint, bank reference. A follow-up in writing is what moves a complaint from a queue to a person.
4. Day 3: one professional conversation. A counsellor, a school psychologist or the child's doctor. Not because the child is fragile, but because a neutral adult is often the person a child will actually talk to.
5. Week 1: tell the school only what is needed. Enough for them to watch for bullying; not so much that the child becomes a story.
6. Month 1: review the settings that failed. Something in the setup allowed this. Find it, fix it, and tell the child what you changed.

> **Three things parents do that make it worse**
> Taking the phone away as a punishment for disclosing. Deleting the evidence to protect the child's reputation. Confronting the offender directly. Each one is understandable, and each one reliably increases the harm — the first because it guarantees silence next time, the second because it destroys the case, the third because it escalates.

CHAPTER 26

The reporting ladder

There is no single correct door. Use whichever is fastest for the situation, and keep a record of every reference number.

Channel	Use it for	How
Platform report	Removal of content, account action, impersonation	In-app report flow, plus the platform's grievance channel in writing; keep the ticket number
cybercrime.gov.in	Any cybercrime, with a dedicated category for women and children; anonymous reporting is available	National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal, run under the I4C of the Ministry of Home Affairs
1930	Financial cyber fraud, immediately	National cyber-financial fraud helpline, available 24x7
112	Immediate danger, or a child missing right now	National emergency response number
1098	A child in distress or in need of care and protection	Child helpline, free, and a child can call it themselves
POCSO e-Box	Any sexual offence against a child, reported confidentially	NCPCR's online complaint box at ncpcr.gov.in
Police station	A formal FIR, in any of the above	Any station, regardless of where the offence happened — the zero-FIR principle applies
School	Anything involving classmates or school platforms	Written email to teacher and principal with evidence attached

How to write a complaint that gets acted on

1. State the facts in date order, with times. No adjectives, no speculation.
2. Name the platform, the account handle and the URL for every piece of content.
3. Say plainly that the subject is a minor, with the date of birth.
4. Quote the obligation you are invoking where one applies — for intimate or morphed images, the two-hour removal requirement under Rule 3(2)(b) of the IT Rules, 2021.
5. Attach the evidence as files, not as links that can be deleted.
6. Ask for a written acknowledgement and a reference number, and follow up in writing if none arrives.

> **Why the written version matters**
> A phone call produces sympathy; a written complaint with a reference number produces a duty. Every channel above issues a reference, and every one of them can be followed up. Keep the numbers in a single note on your phone, titled with the year.

CHAPTER 27

The law in plain English

You do not need to be a lawyer to use the law. You need to know which section to name, so that a complaint is treated as a complaint rather than as a worry.

The four laws that apply

Law	What it covers	The parts that matter to a parent
POCSO Act, 2012	Sexual offences against children	S.11 and s.12: sexual harassment, including through electronic means. S.13 and s.14: using a child in media for sexual purposes. S.15: storing or failing to report such material. An AI-generated sexual image of a real child falls here
IT Act, 2000 and IT Rules, 2021	Online content and platform duties	S.66E: publishing a private image without consent. S.67B: child sexual abuse material. Rule 3(2)(b): removal within two hours for intimate or morphed content, since 20 February 2026
Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023	General criminal offences	S.78: stalking, including online. S.351: criminal intimidation. S.353: false or misleading information causing public mischief
DPDP Act, 2023 and DPDP Rules, 2025	Children's personal data	S.9: verifiable parental consent, and no tracking or targeted advertising at children. Rule 10: how consent is verified. Fully in force 13 May 2027

What the penalties look like

Under the Schedule to the DPDP Act, a breach of the children's obligations under section 9 can attract a penalty of up to Rs 200 crore. The Act's overall ceiling, Rs 250 crore, applies to a failure to take reasonable security safeguards. These are ceilings, not automatic fines: the Data Protection Board must complete an inquiry, find the breach significant, hear the party, and apply seven statutory factors before setting an amount.

What the law does not do

- It does not make a platform liable for every harmful thing a user posts — the obligations are about process, notice and speed.
- It does not remove content by itself. A complaint starts a clock; the platform acts on the clock.
- It does not give a parent a right to read a child's messages. No Indian law does that, and any product claiming to is not telling you the truth.
- It does not replace a lawyer. For an adversarial dispute, a police complaint or a court matter, engage one — and bring the section numbers above with you.

> **One date to remember**
> 13 May 2027. That is when the children's provisions of the DPDP Act become fully enforceable, when verifiable parental consent becomes an obligation rather than a design choice, and when the penalty ceiling of Rs 200 crore becomes live. Everything you see platforms doing in 2026 — age prompts, consent screens, teen modes — is preparation for that date.

CHAPTER 28

Working with the school

Schools are where most of this harm actually starts, and they are also the institution most able to stop it. The difference is almost always whether a parent put something in writing.

The three emails that do the work

1. At the start of the year: the policy email

> '*Dear [teacher], could you share in writing: (a) the school's policy on students using AI tools for homework and projects; (b) which online learning platforms the school uses and what student data they hold; and (c) who the designated child protection or counselling contact is for online safety concerns. Thank you.*'

2. When an incident involves classmates

> '*I am writing to report an incident involving [child] and other students of [class], which took place on [platform] on [date]. I have attached screenshots. I am asking for: a written acknowledgement, a statement of what the school will do, and confirmation of whether the incident has been reported to the police as required. I am also informing the platform and the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal.*'

3. When the school posts photographs

> '*Please confirm the school's policy on publishing photographs of students, including class photographs and event albums, and whether parents may opt out. Could you also confirm whether images are posted to public accounts or to closed groups?*'

What to ask for, specifically

- A named contact for online safety, and how a student reaches them without going through a teacher they fear.
- A written AI policy for homework, with one rule per subject if possible.
- A no-tolerance line on group chats that target a student, and a route to report one.
- Confirmation that the school will not publish full names with photographs, or the school name and class in public posts.

> **The leverage you actually have**
> Schools respond to written records, not to anger. One email, sent politely, with evidence attached and a request for a written reply, moves further than three phone calls. Keep every reply in a folder. If a school fails to act on a known incident involving a child, that failure is itself a matter the child protection authorities take seriously.

PART SIX

Tools

Three chapters: a dated 30-day plan, printable checklists, and the full source log so you can check anything in this book yourself.

CHAPTER 29

The 30-day rollout plan

Doing all of this in one weekend does not work. Twenty minutes a day, in this order, does.

Days	What you do	Time
1-3	Chapter 12 audit. Decide the four household rules: where phones sleep, who approves installs, the money rule, and the network filter.	20 min each
4-6	Fix birth dates on every account and link the family account. This unlocks every default in Part Three.	15 min each
7-9	Android: Family Link (Chapter 13). iPhone: Screen Time and Ask to Buy (Chapter 14). One device per evening.	20 min each
10-12	YouTube: supervised account, content level, blocked channels, autoplay off, Shorts limit (Chapter 15).	15 min each
13-15	Instagram: supervision link, hidden words, time limit, Sleep Mode (Chapter 16).	15 min each
16-17	WhatsApp: privacy, groups, unknown callers, two-step verification, linked devices (Chapter 17).	10 min each
18-20	AI apps: the age table, parental links, quiet hours, remove adults-only apps (Chapter 18).	20 min each
21-23	The conversation. Print the agreement (Chapter 20), negotiate two clauses, sign it.	One evening
24-25	Homework protocol (Chapter 23). Put the prompt on the wall. Do one teach-back.	20 min
26-27	Save the four numbers. Write the family's reporting note. Read Chapter 25 together.	20 min
28	The school email (Chapter 28).	10 min
29-30	Review: what did we not do, and what did we decide to leave? Write it down. Book the three-month review.	20 min

Why a 30-day plan and not a checklist

Because a checklist you never finish produces guilt, and guilt produces nothing. A plan that ends with a written note of what you deliberately left out produces a working household system. Leaving something out on purpose is a decision; leaving it out by exhaustion is a gap.

CHAPTER 30

Printable checklists and the quarterly review

Two pages to print: the setup checklist and the review. The review is what keeps this from decaying into a phone that was configured once in 2026.

The setup checklist

- Real birth date on every account, including Google, Apple, Instagram, WhatsApp and every AI app.
- Family link active: Family Link (Android), Family Sharing (Apple), Family Centre (Meta).
- Install approval on: Play Store via Family Link, or Ask to Buy on Apple.
- No card, no UPI, no saved payment method on the child's device.
- Bedroom charging rule in place, applied to adults too.
- Network-level family DNS set on the router.
- YouTube: supervised account or supervised teen account, content level set, autoplay off, Shorts limit set.
- Instagram: private, DMs restricted, hidden words on, Sleep Mode on, time limit set, school name removed from bio.
- WhatsApp: privacy set to contacts, groups restricted, unknown callers silenced, two-step verification on.
- AI apps: age correct, teen mode active, parental link on where available, adults-only apps removed.
- Location: precise location off in camera and in every app that asks.
- The four numbers saved: 1930, 112, 1098, cybercrime.gov.in.
- The agreement printed and signed.

The quarterly review, four questions

1. What new app appeared? Open the app list together. New app, same rules: age, approval, privacy.
2. What rule did we break, and was it the rule or the reason for it? Change the rule if the reason no longer applies.
3. What did we not do last quarter, and are we doing it or dropping it? Write the answer down.
4. Is the agreement still right for this age? Every birthday is a renegotiation. Move one notch towards agreement and away from blocking each year.

> **Put the next review in the calendar now**
> Three months from today, with the child's name in the title. A review that is not scheduled does not happen, and a setup from 2026 protecting a child in 2028 is a false sense of safety.

CHAPTER 31

Sources and verification log

Everything factual in this playbook was checked in October 2026 against the sources below. Where a date or a rule could change, the date of the check is given so you can tell how current the statement is.

Indian law and government sources

- Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023 — s.9 (children), s.33 and the Schedule (penalties, including Rs 200 crore for children's obligations).
- Digital Personal Data Protection Rules, 2025 — G.S.R. 846(E), notified 13 November 2025; Rule 1 (commencement), Rule 10 (verifiable parental consent), Fourth Schedule (exemptions).
- MeitY and PIB releases on the DPDP Rules and the phased 18-month timeline, including the Data Protection Board (November 2025) and Consent Managers (November 2026).
- Information Technology (Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code) Rules, 2021, as amended with effect from 20 February 2026 — Rule 3(2)(b) two-hour removal for intimate, morphed and impersonation content.
- POCSO Act, 2012 — s.11, s.12, s.13, s.14, s.15.
- Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023 — s.78, s.351, s.353.
- NCRB, Crime in India 2024 — 1,87,702 crimes against children registered in 2024.
- Ministry of Home Affairs, Rajya Sabha reply, March 2026 — NCRP reporting volumes for 2021-2025.
- PIB, March 2026 — cybercrime cases against children, 232 in 2018 to 1,240 in 2024; reporting channels including cybercrime.gov.in, 1930, 112, 1098 and the POCSO e-Box.
- NCERT/CIET and NCPCR material on cyber safety, cyberbullying and reporting for schools.

Platform documentation

- OpenAI — Terms of Use and Help Centre: ChatGPT for Teens, age requirements, parental controls (checked October 2026).
- Google — Family Link, YouTube supervised experiences, content settings (Explore, Explore more, Most of YouTube), Shorts feed limits including the zero option from March 2026, Family Centre teen supervision (checked October 2026).
- Meta — Family Centre, Instagram Teen Accounts in India, the 13+ content setting rollout of April 2026, supervision features including Meta AI topic visibility (checked October 2026).
- WhatsApp — privacy settings and the August 2026 confirmation of age-confirmation testing in India.
- Character.AI — under-18 chat changes announced October 2025, effective from 25 November 2025 in the US and expanding afterwards; Parental Insights.
- Anthropic — Claude consumer terms, 18+.
- Microsoft — Copilot for young people and Microsoft Family Safety.

What is deliberately not in this book

No app recommendations, because the app market changes faster than a PDF can follow. No claim that any setting makes a child safe, because none does. No monitoring software, because the evidence and the ethics both point the same way: a child who is secretly surveilled stops telling you things, and the telling is the protection.

> **If a setting has moved**
> Platforms rename menus constantly. The logic does not change: find the family, supervision or wellbeing section of the app, and the same four controls will be there — who can contact the child, what the child can see, how long they can use it, and who can see the activity. If you cannot find it, search the app's own help centre for the words 'parental controls' or 'supervision'.

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